

BLKOUTUK.COM

NOVEMBER 2020

IN THE PICTURE

LONDON'S BLACK
QUEER MEN
IN FOCUS



ROB BERKELEY

For nothing is fixed, forever and forever
and forever, it is not fixed; the earth is
always shifting, the light is always
changing, the sea does not cease to grind
down rock.

Generations do not cease to be born, and
we are responsible to them because we
are the only witnesses they have. The sea
rises, the light fails, lovers cling to each
other, and children cling to us.

The moment we cease to hold each
other, the sea engulfs us and the light goes
out.

JAMES A BALDWIN



Dedicated to Marc Thompson and Antoine Rogers for not
dismissing *every* cunning plan, and reminding me to smile,
to Clarence Patton for the soundtrack and the perspective,
and to all those who came looking for answers, only to find
more questions, and stayed anyway.

Rob Berkeley *October 2020*

‘Less charity, more justice’

Alain Locke described a new ‘vision of opportunity’ emerging among Black people in the US, 50 years after the enslaved gained their emancipation. His 1925 essay became the manifesto for the Harlem Renaissance. 50 years after decriminalization of homosexuality in the UK, his analysis echoes for Black Queer Men in London, who have been regarded as ,,,

“more of a formula than a human being ... His shadow, so to speak, has been more real to him than his personality. Through having had to appeal from the unjust stereotypes of his oppressors and traducers to those of his liberators, friends and benefactors he has subscribed to the traditional positions from which his case has been viewed. Little true social or self-understanding has or could come from such a situation ... We have not been watching in the right direction; set North and South on a sectional axis, we have not noticed the East till the sun has us blinking.”

‘Enter The New Negro’
Alain Locke (1925)

Table of Contents

INTRODUCTION	4
Learning on Lockdown	6
ABOUT THIS REPORT.....	7
ABOUT BLKOUTUK.COM	8
The Research Participants	8
ANALYSIS & DISCUSSION.....	9
Improving the Evidence Base	10
Mental Health Matters	13
Difference makes a difference	16
Space to be free	19
To-do list	22
INTRODUCING WE_ARE_BLKOUT.....	23
Selected Bibliography.....	24

WE_ARE_BLKOUT is a public campaign to introduce BLKOUT_UK to more Black queer men, potential allies, and partners.

We are seeking resources and partnerships that will help us establish more effective ways of working so that we can offer the highest quality of intervention, and ensure that we can be held accountable for what we do in the name of our peers.

WE_ARE_BLKOUT will kickstart our ambitious, five-year investment in Black queer men that will build connections, resilience, power and joy with Black queer men across the country.

CLICK HERE TO [Join our mailing list](#)



In the Picture

London's Black Queer Men in focus



Introduction

In response to mounting anecdotal evidence of unmet needs, BLKOUT_UK set out an ambition to develop beyond our initial goal of creating a community-led forum for dialogue. In 2018, we agreed to establish, in the words of poet Essex Hemphill, '*an organisation to save our lives*'. However, initiating this ambition to enable and encourage targeted interventions and investment in support of Black queer men, we discovered a remarkably weak, formal evidence-base for action.

We were therefore delighted to gain the support of the Mayor of London's community-led research initiative to conduct this research project in 2019. Firstly, because policy-related research, grounded in an agenda set by and for those it is about, remains extremely rare. Secondly, the Mayor's pan-London coordinating role, was reassurance for us and our respondents that the time spent engaging with research would be well spent; used to improve public services, rather than to languish, gathering dust on a shelf as so many well-intentioned policy initiatives do.

We are immensely grateful to our team of peer researchers, and to all those who completed surveys, participated in interviews, or attended our photo shoot.

These are extraordinary times - the anticipated constitutional upheaval of Brexit has been dwarfed by the unprecedented impact of the coronavirus pandemic and the necessary lockdowns to protect lives. Both have shone a light on the way in which our society deals with difference. Twenty years since the [Parekh Report](#) on the future of multi-ethnic Britain called for meaningful efforts to create equitable, values-led social cohesion, and a decade after the [Marmot Review](#) focused attention on the impact of inequality on social determinants of health, COVID-19 has made evident the fatal consequences of inaction.

Parallel to the research process, BLKOUT joined a cohort of organisations supported by [Nesta, the innovation charity](#), to share learning about the formation of social movements for health. This helped to frame our thoughts about how best to centre the needs of Black queer men in what we do, be upfront about our values, and resist the temptation to rush to conclusions to meet timetables or agendas set by others. It has meant thinking radically about where we put our attention and taking the sometimes-slower route to ensure that we build capacity among Black queer men at every step. Lockdown and the prospect of extreme isolation for a group of men already at risk of isolation meant that we had to stretch our resources and innovate in response.

DR ROB
BERKELEY

PRINCIPAL
RESEARCHER &
AUTHOR

*DIRECTOR,
BLKOUT_UK*

LEAD
RESEARCHER

MARC
THOMPSON

PEER
RESEARCH
TEAM

ELLIS
THOMPSON

JEAN-ERIC
NKURIKYE

REECE
WALDRON

PHOTOGRAPHER
BEN GLEAN

We put our emerging knowledge into action and chose to act, despite the tensions that this was likely to cause for our small leadership team who also needed to consider their own self-care. The interventions that we made (below) responded to our understanding of the need for Black Queer men to:



- **Take a lead** - express their agency in support of themselves and each other,
- **Share their light** - to create spaces for joy and that celebrate Black Queer contributions to our shared culture,
- **Stand together** - acknowledge the damage to mental health caused by the trauma of racism and support each other in healing,
- **Raise our voices** - be a visible and vocal part of movements for Black liberation.

This report builds on that experience. **We are not a 'typical' group, and this is not a typical policy report.** Instead, it is presented as a series of four provocations grounded in the research findings; a call to action, and an invitation to innovate with Black Queer men. We aim for this report to act as a contribution to the establishment of a new kind of movement led by those with lived experience.

We sincerely welcome the activation of so many mainstream organisations in providing platforms for Black Queer people and it has been heartening to see greater visibility of individuals and their stories have been inspiring. Black History Month 2020 has really grown in stature from previous years - however, there are few guarantees yet that it, or the other pledges from corporate brands to adopt anti-racist practices, have changed existing systems enough to endure, and there remain significant structural inequalities that visibility alone will not solve. We know, however, that the wheel turns and public attention to issues of racism, sexual identity and inequality wax and wane, and can be weaponised in aid of a culture war, or battles for attention. We, by contrast, commit to staying Black, and staying queer; and building assets that will support resilience and secure space to thrive, even when we are no longer 'flavour of the month'.



Join us in creating a movement ready to face the uncomfortable truths of racism, homophobia, exclusion, and exploitation; one that builds knowledge, capacity and relationships, as assets that can be used to resist the 'new normal' being a return to the same, old inequity that placed limits on the life chances of Black queer men, and deprived our city of the contribution that our talents, energy and perspectives bring.

THANK YOU

This research was made possible due to funding received from the **Mayor of London**. We are particularly grateful to the Community Engagement Team for their insights and patience through this challenging period

LEARNING IN LOCKDOWN

The BLKOUT HUB – Self Care Guide



Unable to meet physically, we sought ways of building a culture of self-care, that challenged notions of self indulgence and included elements of care for community as a significant element of caring for self. We

crowdsourced ideas and resources that were targeted specifically at the concerns of Black Queer Men

The Get Down on LOCKDOWN



The cultural institutions for Black Queer men have revolved around the dancefloor from The Cotton Club to Paradise Garage. Despite being novices at livestreaming we created the 'Get Down on Lockdown' to share an element of

collective joy. So popular, that it crashed our servers, the event demonstrated the need for social spaces that reflected and celebrated us, even in pandemic isolation

Breathe 8.46



The senseless, racist murder of George Floyd in Minnesota saw our social media timelines once again filled with images of Black death and despair. We developed Breathe 8.46 as a targeted series of

interventions to support Black Queer men to access space to acknowledge and heal from trauma, through music, exercise, meditation, silence or reflection, and gather the energy to continue to mobilise against racism.

Black Queer Lives Matter



The demonstrations in support of Black Lives across the UK represented a significant shift in progress towards racial justice. A new generation of activists took the reins and were keen to assert that this movement would be inclusive of

queer voices. We were able to take part in the virtual protest - similarly new terrain - reaching over 30,000 people with a series of videos that supported learning about why ensuring that Black Queer Lives Matter is a necessary anti-racist task.



About this report

This report focuses on four areas emerging from the research and makes recommendations on next steps.

It does so, not to offer the 'final word' on the needs and experiences of Black Queer Men in London. Instead, this report should be viewed as a conversation starter - a springboard for further discussion and engagement responsive to Black Queer men, in the context of the organisations, social actors, opportunities and constraints of what is predicted to be a period of severe economic, social and public policy challenge.

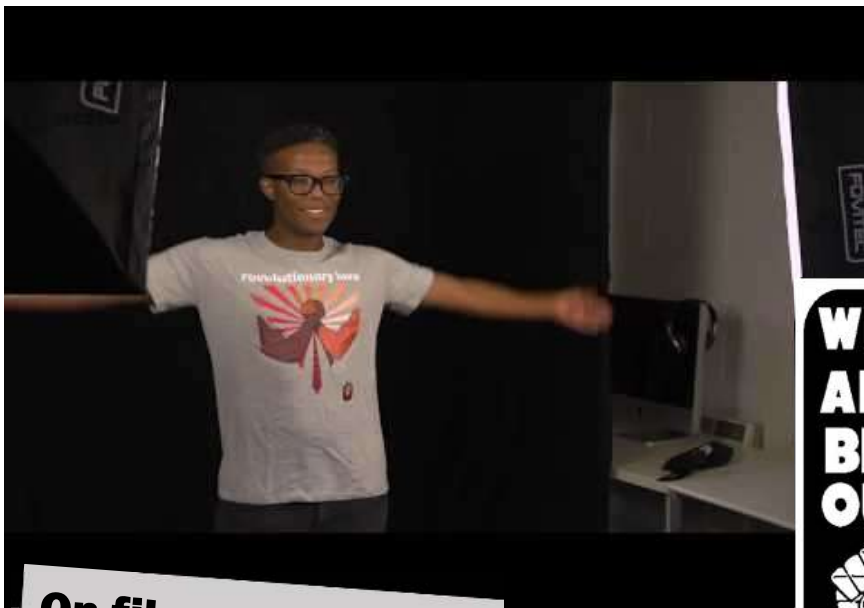
Participatory research

By us, for us

We aim to be part of a movement in which Black queer men have a meaningful stake - transparent, accountable, and values-led. *'In The Picture'* gave us an opportunity to trial ways of working with and engaging Black queer men in shaping a shared agenda. The research team members identified as Black bi/gay men/non-binary. In addition, we involved other Black queer men from beyond the research group in supporting the analysis. We adopted a mixed-methods approach and where possible worked towards a participatory model of research and policy development.

1. We recruited researchers through an open recruitment process, offering any Black queer men who applied a role or research skills training after completing a skills audit. We assembled a team of five researchers, who were additionally incentivized to recruit Black queer men as respondents from their own networks. We held a workshop to design the qualitative interview schedule together.
2. We consulted stakeholders, including our GLA partners, and invited input from BLKOUT Collective members about the topic guide and questionnaire design. Understanding patterns of inequality in access to tools to make change was identified as a top priority, so we adapted our survey from the **GLA's Survey of Londoners and the *Community Life* national survey to enable comparisons to be made**. We received 100 responses to the survey that was completed online and conducted in depth semi-structured interviews with 15 men.
3. We **hosted a photo shoot** in Jan 2020 with a Black queer photographer, as a way of further promoting the project. The shoot provided us with an informal opportunity for participants to meet each other, engage in discussions about the research, and offer their ideas for dissemination.
4. A planned content analysis workshop with the research team was **abandoned due to the pandemic**. This was replaced by a recorded interview detailing the process of analysis that will form the basis for a contribution to a lecture series on participatory research to postgraduate sociologists at Kings College, University of London.
5. This report includes analysis of data collected between Sept and Dec 2019. This marks a step rather than an end of our learning journey; we will be **using the dissemination process as an exercise in movement building**; inviting key civil society stakeholders to publicly commit to increased efforts to understand the needs and experiences of Black queer men, by sharing research, stimulating improved knowledge management, and where possible taking collective, accountable action to improve outcomes and life chances of Black Queer men.
6. We are working towards convening **an academic conference in 2021 (Brother to Brother UK @40)** with the aim of supporting capacity within the academy to respond to an agenda for research driven by concern for our liberation. We will through this event and other means continue our efforts to improve the evidence base for action and more equitable resource distribution.

ABOUT BLKOUTUK.COM



On film:

BLKOUT UK - a social movement
for us, by us



12
PRINCIPLES
FOR
ACTION

Values-led: 12 Principles Shared

WE ARE BECOMING ... ENOUGH ... NOT ALL THE SAME	WE BELIEVE THAT THE WHOLE IS GREATER THAN THE SUM OF ITS PARTS ... OUR GLASS IS ALWAYS HALF FULL ... THE TIME IS NOW
MAKING BLACK QUEER LIVES MATTER	
WE UNDERSTAND THAT UNRESOLVED TRAUMA HAS A REAL IMPACT IN OUR LIVES ... JUSTICE AND SOLIDARITY TAKE WORK ... NO ONE IS FREE UNTIL EVERYONE IS FREE	WE PRACTICE ACCOUNTABILITY ... LEARNING ... JOY

Gender

93% identified as male

7% Gender non-conforming/Non-binary

Religion/Belief

Christian 49%

Muslim 4%

(30% practicing)

Employment/Education

43% had a university degree

31% worked in public sector

THE RESEARCH PARTICIPANTS

Age

53% Under 35 years old

Sexual identity

76% identified as gay men

17% as bisexual

Ethnicity

Black Caribbean 29%

Black African 36%

Mixed heritage 24%

(17% dual home language)

TRANS MEN

Our efforts to engage Black trans men in this research were unsuccessful. This remains a significant gap in this report (and in the existing research). We remain keen to work with partners to address this gap, and ensure that Black trans men's voices are included.

ANALYSIS & DISCUSSION





1. IMPROVING THE EVIDENCE BASE

‘Nobody Knows the Trouble I’ve Seen’

Visibility in data and evidence for action

Next year’s census will include a new voluntary question on sexual identity. Finally enabling the provisions of the Equality Act that outlaw unfair discrimination against LGBTQ+ members of the population to be subject to similar levels of evidence-based scrutiny as other protected identities. Unlikely to report until 2024, current evidence and recent history suggest that, without intervention, the data collected on Black bi, gay and trans men will fail to deliver the insights that we hope.

In reviewing the current state of reliable survey evidence on groups at the intersection of race and sexual orientation for this study, it has become clear that Black queer men, in particular, appear resistant to sharing information about their identity - at least with officialdom. A voluntary census question is unlikely to automatically change this pattern, while demanding a compulsory response seems politically unpalatable. The level of ‘proof’ of need for a group of this size, for whom privacy is a crucial factor in their identity and safety, may require a different approach to evidence and the development of greater levels of trust between public services and community interlocutors. The quest for ever more evidence when it is so difficult to collect, may become viewed as an excuse not to act rather than a commitment to [‘evidence-based policy’](#).

Lockdown hours spent at home in front of multiple screens, seemed to turn the British public into population data scientists; discussing ‘R’ rates, rejecting the BAME aggregate categorization, and offering views on the reliability or otherwise of health statistics. Most markedly data science became vital in relationship to the revelation (to many) that racism kills; sometimes in the form of a police officer kneeling on your neck, sometimes via the air that making a living requires you to share with others.

For *‘In The Picture’* after extending promotion efforts and the survey availability period twice, we achieved over 400 unique survey ‘starts’, but only 100 completions. Dismayed, we looked for examples where larger numbers of Black queer men had completed surveys, only to discover that reaching 100 completed surveys from one city made this one of the largest datasets from Black bi/gay/trans men - the largest found were the 2014 Gay Men’s Sex Survey that achieved 320 Black (including Mixed Black and White) respondents, and the 2017 National LGBT Survey, completed by 275 Black men (including 35 Black trans men, but excluding those identifying as Mixed Black and White). Assuming equal distribution of same-sex attraction across ethnic groups, Black and Asian men were the least likely to engage with either of these surveys despite targeted advertising, outreach contracts issued to community organisations (GMSS) and large marketing budgets.

This lack of engagement poses problems for organising among- or arguing for resources to address the needs of- Black queer men. In a 2016 systematic review of effective interventions for black and minority ethnic men who have sex with men, [Jaspal et al note](#);

the existing evidence base suffers from some methodological limitations, such as the existence of conflicting and limited evidence which can preclude the formation of robust interventions.

There would appear to have been little progress made in addressing these limitations in intervening years. A continuing time-lag in closing this data gap or adopting new approaches to evidence may be costing lives.

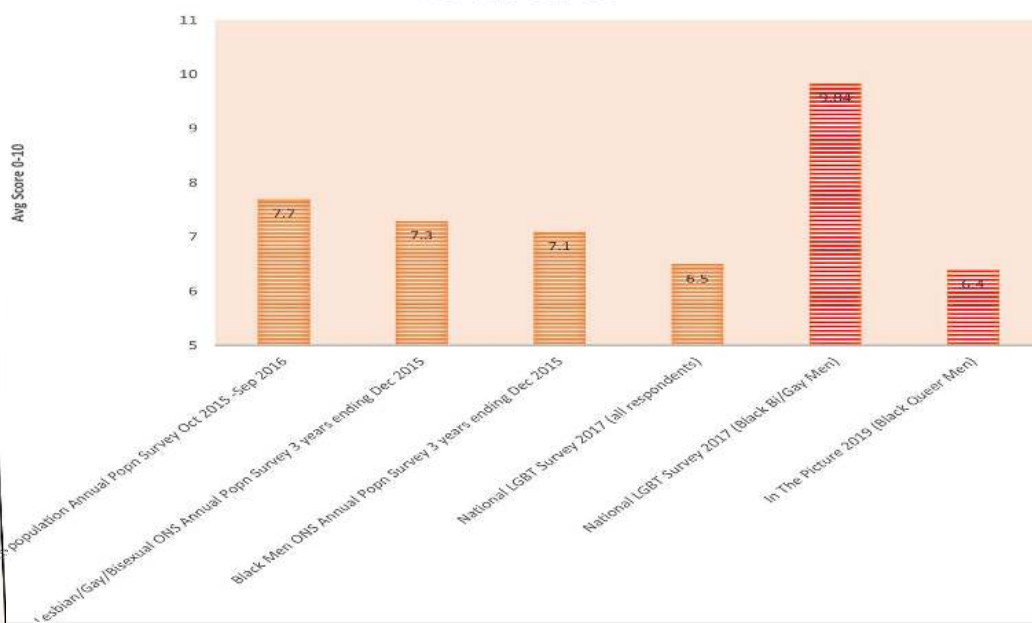
Are Black Queer Men more, or less, satisfied with their lives than average?

3 surveys, one question, and it's STILL hard to tell

Check the small-print

It can be tempting to overstate the validity of findings re intersectional groups - in frustration at the weakness of the data. In 2017, a widely quoted You Gov-Stonewall report stated that 3/5 Black LGBT people experienced 'discrimination or poor treatment' in LGBT spaces and were nearly 2x as likely to be victim to intimate partner violence. On closer inspection these conclusions were based on just 107 respondents. Such data is important but indicative rather than representative

Q. OVERALL, HOW SATISFIED ARE YOU WITH YOUR LIFE?



To do ...

1. Undertake pre-emptive work to reassure Black Queer men that completing Census 2021 will not expose them to risk and lead to improved outcomes for themselves and their peers.
2. Use alternative sources and forms of research data and modes of data stewardship that generate trust e.g. [data trusts](#). Alternative sources include dating apps. Trust is crucial to capitalize on opportunities/ address threats to freedom posed by big data and AI, threats that risk reinforcing patterns of invisibility and exclusion.

...in 2021

“The council ... didn't really see me as a priority ... there was no emotional intelligence to understand what it is to be Black and queer on their side. I had to kind of explain it to them - I felt like ... they had no foundations”

Collection, use, and management, of data about Black Queer Men, is only made so vitally necessary because services are managed as a competition between citizens for limited resources, adjudicated by public 'servants'.

At base, demand for 'perfect information' before action, is due to the social distance between Black queer men and those making policy or resource decisions on their behalf.

We need systems that design and deliver services with rather than for Black queer men; meeting them where they are, valuing differences, sharing risks, reward, and accountability; building trust/ networks with and among them.

“

I seemed like a novelty when I walked in there. This big black gay man and there was two black women in there, and I remember them coming into the room just to look

I thought she was ... nuanced. That comes from engagement or research, or the knowledge she had about my identity, that clearly played a role in the kind of service I received.

I think that generally you're not really aware of the serious or the more focused or driven group of black gay men. When you speak of black gay men, you generally think of the ones who go out clubbing all the time; always hanging out

I thought I was the only queer Somali person. But finding all these others, I feel like there are people who were in my situation six, seven years ago and after my teens.

Knowledge is very important: Knowledge is power

Our contribution to this City is unquantifiable, because there's a lot of people who we don't even know that they're queer, and... so, yeah, I think we're everywhere, and I think perhaps the people making the biggest contributions are the unsung heroes, to be honest ... I feel that there are a lot of people, a lot of queer men and women, out there doing stuff, but their sexuality isn't necessarily front line.

”

2. MENTAL HEALTH MATTERS



'Changing Your Mind'
*Mental Health risks, unresolved trauma, plus
ineffective coping strategies - and persistent
system inertia*

The experience of working alongside Black Queer Men has highlighted the levels of trauma that are a common part of our lives. Whether due to rejection or acknowledgement of a minoritized sexuality, or as a result of experiences of abuse when vulnerable, or as a product of '[minority stress](#)', trauma takes its toll. While the risk factors for poorer mental health and how they intersect with Black queer men's lives are relatively well known, there appears to have been very limited, sustained intervention from statutory or voluntary services to mitigate these risks that are rooted in Black queer experiences

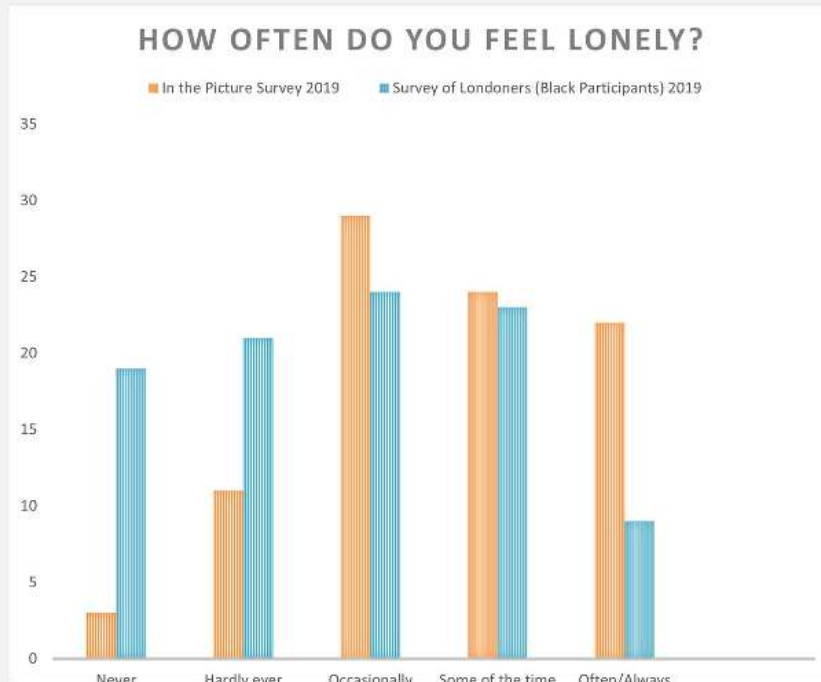
[A recent NHS publication](#) sets out what is known in relation to various protected identities about inequalities in our mental health system. It highlights the persistent patterns of poor access to timely psychological treatments for Black men that lead to a higher proportion presenting at mental health services in crisis, followed by a poorer in-patient experience, and less successful outcomes after treatment. [Mental health advocacy organisations](#) and NHS leaders regularly bemoan the lack of progress in addressing this pattern, despite the mounting evidence. Evidence also points to lower rates of access, lower levels of patient satisfaction and weaker outcomes from treatment for LGB and Trans people. [Recent studies](#) have noted LGBTQ+ people are more than twice as likely to experience depression and four times as likely to attempt suicide. In addition to minority stress, in gay and bisexual men there is increasing support for the theory that disproportionality can be explained by the "*corrosive effects of status consciousness, competitiveness and racism within the gay community itself*". Black Queer Men are likely to face a combination of these risk factors. It is notable that, at the time of writing, there has not been a research or practice focus on systematically addressing the mental health needs of the group at this particular identity intersection. In response to need for targeted support identified via [BLKOUT interventions](#), we have welcomed emerging community-led work from Naz Project London, GMFA, and Black Thrive in South London. Unfortunately, so far, funding has replicated the project-based short-termism that has shown weaker results in the past, despite the considerable energy and insight put in.

The outcome of combined stressors/risk factors of racism and homophobia, and lack of perceived-as-appropriate services/access to support can manifest in behaviours that reinforce risks. [Researchers theorise](#) that higher levels of alcohol and substance misuse among Black queer men results. The turn from bar/club to 'dating' app, subcultures of 'chemsex' - for an [estimated 10 percent](#) of men who have sex with men, higher prevalence of HIV with (again) lower levels of access to psychological support when compared to white bi/gay men living with HIV, may also be a driver towards (potential) disproportionality. The use of illicit drugs renders participants vulnerable to exploitation, addiction, and other health related risks, and increases proximity to the criminal justice system that [persistently delivers harsher sentences to Black men for drug offences](#).

We should be mindful not to locate the risk of poor mental health in identities rather than in the way in which those identities are received and responded to within our society. It is racism and homophobia that drive patterns of 'status consciousness', poorer access to services, alienation and loneliness, and lower socio-economic status, rather than being inherent in Blackness or queerness. Interventions are required to reduce the impact of- and increase Black queer men's resilience to- the racism and homophobia in our society. It is for this reason that the data collected during '*In The Picture*', and subsequent surveys during the first wave coronavirus lockdown (e.g. by [LGBTHero](#)) regarding near epidemic levels of loneliness and alienation among Black Queer Men give us such cause for concern.

Our survey respondents reported high levels of anxiety, loneliness and unhappiness. Worryingly, across all of the measures of wellbeing that featured in the survey, there was a marked negative difference between the experience reported by Black Queer men in London, when compared to fellow Black Londoners.

Even before the COVID-19 lockdown, Black Queer men in London experienced loneliness much more often than Black Londoners generally



To do...

1. Co-design and delivery of systematic, long-term, interventions to support Black Queer Men's mental wellbeing, related to their life stage, should be a priority in improving the mental health of the capital's, and feature in the government's efforts to curb the impact of loneliness
2. Invest and innovate in digital tech to provide a suite of mental health support responsive to need; include access to talking therapies, healing justice groupwork, mental wellbeing, and mindfulness: normalising Black men seeking support from services and each other at an earlier stage

2021

"the first two years of me basically being out and exploring the London scene wasn't really a good time for me. But that's mainly because I hadn't found any black queer spaces at that point"

"I think it's just within us as black queer people of colour to sometimes brush things under the carpet."

"[Being] myself ...comes at a price ... possible violence and estrangement."

Given the combined risk factors experienced by Black Queer men, each of us should have access to relevant, high quality mental health provision, opportunities to heal from trauma, and opportunities to create/review ongoing access rather than piecemeal support.

“

And I feel like with this generation there's definitely... well, I feel it, a new sense of camaraderie, and we acknowledge each other and we see each other and we're like, "Yeah, let's all sit at the table." And I think... and then that's what I'm loving. I'm loving that there is a brotherhood and a sisterhood that I didn't feel that much back in the day and I didn't see it as much and now I see it and it's... I feel a part of it. So yeah, the brotherhood and the family.

My family, for example. That's the kind of support I would really appreciate. Clearly being openly black and queer has changed that, so that means ... Just kind of that link. I think ideally, I want to be able to hang out with them, have conversations. Not having that emotional support because of my identity. I don't think anyone deserves that

As an artist, that's part of your job, to deal with your emotions and reflect on them and talk.

But I don't think certain black queer men get that. They might not be out, they might be down low, there might be other circumstances, they can't feel like they're being themselves or talk about how they feel, so all these emotions get pent up as stress and anxiety

with everything that's pitted against us, we become this close-knitted family and you do tend to see a lot of the same people at events, then you get to build more of a relationship with them naturally.

What would I do?

Push more money into mental health support. 100%

I've always found that we've had to push harder. We've had to be doubly better, and after a while people get tired of that

”



3. DIFFERENCE MAKES A DIFFERENCE

It won't be you!

*Beyond postcode lotteries; from place to
people-based policy*

A recurring fault-line in public policy is leading to alienation and a waste of potential among Black queer men, and other groups that currently make demands on public services disproportionate to their population share. This line is largely ideological, sustained by bureaucratic habit, and driven by a misplaced desire for social control. It becomes evident in the tension between diversity-led innovation, and locality based social cohesion. While political rhetoric asserts that *integration is a two-way street*, political reality demands one-way traffic. Many Black queer men are very accustomed to negotiating this line between embracing and celebrating the potentialities of freedom to be different, and conformity with norms, that can, by contrast, feel like a straitjacket. Responding more positively to diversity and focusing on the (potential) strength of citizens' networks, rather than seeking to impose a shape on them. Timidity and fear of difference can curb potential to unleash diversity as an engine of creativity, reduce levels of alienation, and build more sustainable networks of support, for those serially excluded or currently vulnerable to isolation.

There are [limits to benefits from place-based decision-making](#) for those who find primary sources of solidarity and identity beyond neighbourhood, ward, or borough boundary. These limits remain, even after a period of lockdown during which many people did not leave their postcode for several weeks.

The lack of local engagement among our survey respondents, in choices about civil society volunteering locally, as well as interactions with neighbours, was stark. Interviewees described an active distancing from neighbours to maintain a level of privacy, avoid any threat that racism or homophobia could make home less of a sanctuary, or establish psychologically draining inauthentic relationships. Galop's [2019 hate crime](#) report noted 1 in 5 would be uncomfortable with LGBT+ neighbours. Similar to the request to '*bring your whole selves to work*', there can be greater risks involved for those who are marginalised, or recovering from the trauma of rejection by a community that once offered them solace, or who feel greater security with an ability to 'code-switch' for self-protection. Expecting uniform levels of engagement with neighbourhood may be asking some to sacrifice their psychological safety, with few guarantees that neighbours are ready to accept them, and limited recourse to support should even a few neighbours take exception to their presence.

As many as a third of our respondents had *never* spoken to their neighbour more than to say 'hello'. Over half of them preferred to '*keep themselves to themselves/choose their friends*'. A quarter claimed that they were too busy to pass the time of day or for a chat over the garden fence. This 'choice' is clearly a factor in the higher than average levels of loneliness for this group; however they appeared willing to risk loneliness over engaging with neighbours; viewing potentially hostile reactions worth avoiding.

The implications of the desire of the group to 'keep themselves to themselves' is significant for local cohesion and the slew of initiatives and funding directed at neighbourhood level organising. It may be a factor in why leadership of local neighbourhood initiatives has remained stubbornly white and [ethnic diversity among London's local councillors](#) remains so unrepresentative.

In the face of this evidence policymakers should consider whether neighbourhood is the right unit of measurement for citizens' wellbeing, or whether a focus on 'left behind areas' is a distraction from addressing the needs of left behind people, as inequalities *within* areas are ignored. If neighbourhood is the prime unit, then how can different attitudes to neighbourhood best be accommodated? Is it by

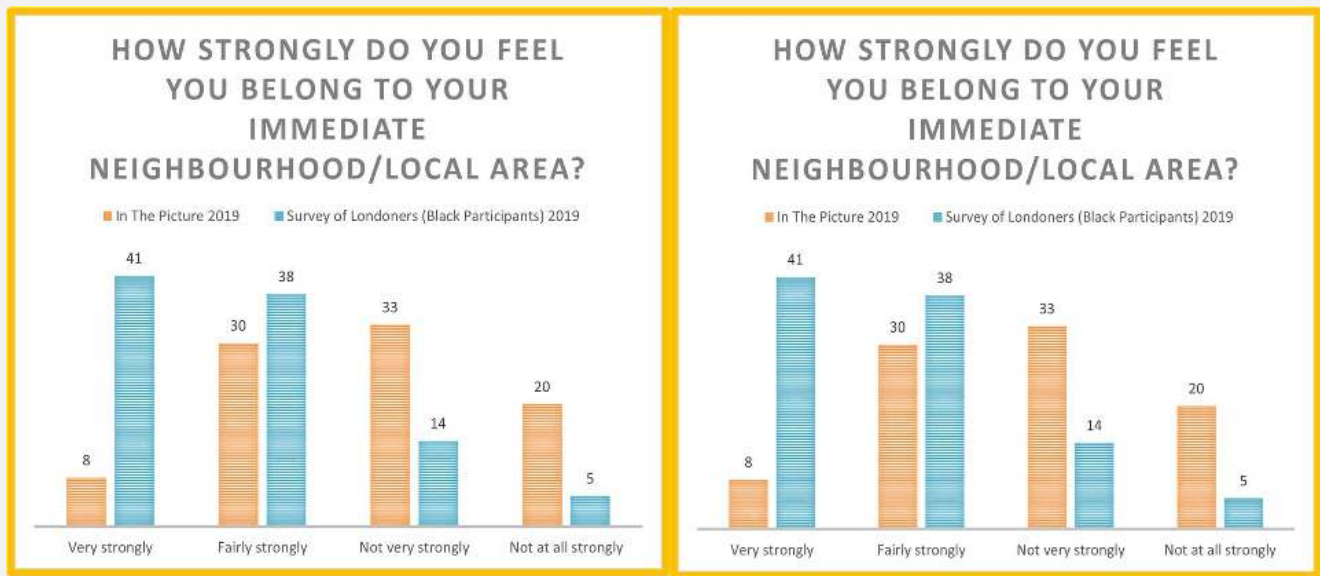
- a) changing neighbourhoods, for example by supporting group clustering through community led-housing for Black queer people, similar to that being developed by [L&Q and London Older Lesbians](#);

cont . . .

- b) by seeking to change attitudes among Black queer men, building their skills, capacity, and confidence to participate locally; or
- c) through changing local infrastructure organisations to make them more welcoming and open to difference.

Across London, we believe that there will be benefits in a mix of all three approaches. Resourcing each approach sufficiently and documenting learning from each would begin to address what has been a long-standing conundrum for community development initiatives that like us, have to operate in the world as it is now, on their journey to the world as we may like it to be.

Failing to encourage greater diversity of approaches and connections in fear that bonding social capital will generate 'too much difference', has repeatedly seen greater benefits from local initiatives accrue to white middle-class groups despite honourable intentions for greater levels of redistribution to marginalised groups. What may have already been lost in terms of potential is too difficult to estimate.



To do . . .

1. Convene key potential partners to create innovative options in co-housing or housing co-operatives that would support Black queer men to support each other. Engage imaginations by modeling a neighbourhood in their image where difference could thrive
2. Work with locally focused organisations to support action, innovation and learning about inclusion for equity within as well as between areas supporting a cohort of Black Queer men into governance and executive roles in community sector.

"... some people just verbally attacked us because of the way we were dressed or because my friends were acting ... being loud and queer

I just decided to avoid being out in my neighbourhood at certain times of the night and told my friends to tone their queerness down ... not calling attention to ourselves."

Eschew 'slippery slope' arguments that sacrifice the marginalised on the altar of policy coherence, while just so happening to maintain power with an unspoken whiteness, in favour of a more fluid approach to enabling groups to build community around identity and cluster in ways that enrich them and the city.

“

I'd want them to go somewhere where I felt culturally they were going to be understood and addressed sympathetically. I don't know that if I think of other nonspecific organizations I could be sure of that

I think as black queer men there's a lot we need to do in terms of supporting people who are more vulnerable than we are, such as our trans siblings.

you've asked me specifically about being black and queer, it would be my friendships with other black queer folk. That's the thing I enjoy most

I was uncomfortable with very entitled white men in Soho or certain clubs, who go out of their way to be so forward and made you feel uncomfortable, but play down your experience whenever you brought it up. Yeah, I really did not like that, being in Soho and that.

I can become anonymous here if I want to

I'm from Barbados, and there, privacy is very much not something that you can really hold on to . . . I can become a stranger if I want to. I can become more open with people if I want to,

we have a wide variety of gay provisions such as clubs, saunas, that I enjoy, and the uniqueness of being able to go to a party that's primarily black gives you a feeling as though you're back in the Caribbean

we inhabit these spaces nervously all the time.

”

4. SPACE TO BE FREE



A recurring theme for our research respondents was one of space. It has been a significant factor in the years in which BLKOUT has sought to develop its work that we have been unable to identify spaces in London that are owned and/or run by Black Queer men. Participants shared their ideas about what could happen in a space that many felt would give them a greater stake in the city and a means of demonstrating to their peers and families that they were part of a community that had a contribution to make to the civic life of London.

High property prices/demand look set to remain; Brexit, and a global pandemic have not yet caused London's property market to wane. Mayoral intervention in 2019 arrested [the precipitous decline of LGBTQ social spaces](#). Lockdown has meant pubs and clubs have been shut or restricted from opening for 9 months now; many may never reopen. As noted above, a narrow reading of community as neighbourhood means that 'meanwhile', community asset transfer, and s106 gain are not realistic options for marginalised/widely dispersed groups to access. While there has been some good work bringing ethnic diversity to community assets by [Ubele Initiative](#), and the LGBT Homeless shelter/community centre [The Outside Project](#) has broken the mould, spaces available to non-localised community groups are rare. There may be some roots to build on where queer people have formed residential clusters based on historical activism, such as the Brixton Co-operative Housing Association, (based in the building formerly squatted by Olive Morris), however the lack of a 'community anchor' space across the entire city is felt viscerally in the lives of our respondents. In a parallel manner to the [recent survey of people in \(so-called\) 'left behind towns'](#), Black Queer Men expressed demand for a space to meet and connect with others. For many of them it was a significant factor restricting their sense of belonging that there was not a regular space that they felt a sense of ownership over. For others, the Black Lesbian and Gay Centre, documented in Veronica McKenzie's film '*Under Your Nose*', that operated in Peckham in the mid-1980s, represented a halcyon day and they talked about it with a sense of loss.

While aware of efforts to create more general LGBTQ cultural spaces, there was skepticism expressed about whether these spaces would be able to fully reflect and cater for the needs of Black queer men. Participants were appreciative of the spaces that community events borrowed, but there was a sense that we always had to operate in spaces owned by others.

Respondents appreciated the spaces that did exist - in particular, those that were unapologetically focused on queer lives. [Pussy Palace](#) was cited as London's premier example of a space that reflected the kind of freedoms to explore and expand identity, especially for younger men - despite (or perhaps because of) it being a space that is led by queer womxn rather than men. However, even an event like Pussy Palace that has inspired so many, has had to move between various venues and does not yet own a space to call its own. The club spaces that catered to the musical tastes of Black Queer men were seen as incredibly valuable, as spaces to see and be seen, however very few, if any of them were either promoted by Black queer men, or held in Black owned spaces, and some expressed concern about whether this meant that

the clubs were extractive of community wealth. Older men (35+) reflected on earlier venues that were known to reliably attract a Black clientele on certain nights; they discussed the friendships and connections that they had been able to build through meeting people there. They felt that the important functions of these spaces for community building were neglected in the commercial decisions that were made about their viability.

Pop up spaces were recognised as a welcome addition in lieu of spaces permanently focused on Black queer lives. Participants spoke of the importance of the one-off or annual events they had been able to attend such as [UK Black Pride](#) or the [BLKOUT Berto Pasuka Lecture](#), as significant moments in raising their self-esteem and supporting them in feeling part of a larger movement. In response, BLKOUT sped up its plans to develop its monthly '[Black Men Who Brunch](#)' event, hosting two brunches before the COVID lockdown, with the aim to create a regular safer space that offered more than a night club could.

Virtual spaces were also recognized as important and for many were their first introduction to other Black gay men. Pre-lockdown, they were seen as poor substitutes for face-to-face connection, but attitudes are likely to have evolved since then. The increasing ubiquity and sophistication of dating apps as a way of building connections with others was widely recognised (our survey respondents were often early adopters of new media technology). They were also highly conscious that online spaces can be rife with overt and covert racism, and racist abuse on dating apps had begun to be seen as par for the course.

BLKOUT has piloted numerous kinds of events from weekly drinks, to theatre trips, cinema screenings, and workshops. Both the BLKOUT volunteers and participants have expressed a desire for more spaces, but also for these to become regularised rather than one-offs. Black Queer people are not without initiative, and groups have emerged that organize meet ups, book clubs, camping trips, cycle rides, speed dating int. al. Our online app and website have created virtual spaces. We are now at the threshold of stepping up activity in order to build community around these spaces and marshal the energy that goes into their curation; making real the byline that we have employed since the start of 2019 - '*making space for us*'

To do . . .

1. Work with social landlords, local authorities, and developers to **create a community owned space** for arts, enterprise, learning and connection led by and for Black queer men
2. Support enterprise start up skills, incubation and investment and or [self-reliant groups](#) among Black queer men to kick start/develop social businesses, and promote independence

Get them some kind of spaces; definitely need space, just somewhere where you can meet your peers, or peers meet people they want to meet.

I don't know, just some kind of space!

Practice radical joyfulness



“

I DON'T WANT TO BE THE INVISIBLE OLD BLACK MAN. DO YOU KNOW WHAT I MEAN? I WANT TO STILL BE FRONT AND CENTRE, BUT YOU KNOW BACK IN THE DAY, WE USED TO SAY, WHERE ARE THE OLDER BLACK GAY MEN? WELL, WE ARE HERE NOW IN THIS BUILDING. WE ARE AT THIS, WE'RE AT THIS EVENT, I THINK THAT'S HEALTHY, AND I DON'T FEEL THAT THEY'RE LOOKING AT US LIKE, THE F* * K ARE THEY DOING HERE. YOU

I think it's the lack of those spaces basically and having a place where you can actually see your friends and see other members of the black queer community around

[to] not feel that you're always coming out all the time. And also, that you have a voice in that you're visible and you're not always having to explain yourself constantly to people like, "Oh, you're gay", "Oh, but you're black". There are always questions. I think it's just getting rid of the questions and just being

Safe spaces because even though we want to be ourselves and be free, the internal work is massive. If we don't get that right we would run back into that closet. I don't know what that would look like, but I just see what we ... We have our internal work done, figured out, and we're free. That gives us a boost of confidence to navigate the world

it's sad that I cannot think of one organization in Britain that caters primarily, or deeply for problems faced by black gay men. At the moment, it's a shame, a big sadness, that a lot of black gay men have to go to these organizations. Okay, they are doing the best they can. But can they identify with the problem in a way of solving it? My answer is no.

a space where I could be me literally without fear of judgment, where I could rant and just speak up

”



WE_ARE_BLKOUT

MAKING BLACK QUEER LIVES MATTER



JOIN THE MOVEMENT BY US.FOR US

- RAISE YOUR VOICE
- TAKE A LEAD
- SHARE YOUR LIGHT
- STAND TOGETHER



QUEER LIVES MATTER

The end of a beginning. . .

While in the final stages of writing this report, I watched the first Black woman to be appointed 'Minister for Equalities' when asked about the "*paucity of data around health outcomes for LGBT people, perhaps not least in respect of the intersectionality with BAME people in respect of covid*" resort to blissful ignorance as a strategy and reason for inaction. She claimed; '*we have not found that LGBT groups have been disproportionately impacted*'. Given the lack of reliable data it is hard to fathom how she can be so confident that this is true? While she may 'see no ships', we know from this report and others that there are urgent needs remaining unmet among QTPOC. We can deduce from her answer that we will not be able to look to government for aid to meet these needs.

WE_ARE_BLKOUT. We will not give up hope that political leadership will emerge. We anticipate more civil society organisations will one-day move on from hand-wringing about racism to getting their hands dirty doing the work alongside Black people to dismantle the structures in which racism resides. We are excited at the prospect of working with those commercial brands that offered black box pledges to join the anti-racist cause back in June as more than cynical efforts in reputation management for 'woke points'. However, as this report shows, we cannot rely on hope alone. If we are the heroes we have been waiting for, can we rely on us?

In November, WE_ARE_BLKOUT will be the banner under which we will convene a series of discussions online, building on this report. We will also be recruiting a new team of Black Queer men to take their turn in leading our movement. From the start of December, we will be collecting pledges of solidarity from Black Queer men, our allies and partners from our existing network, and launching a public call for more. January will be filled with resolutions.

WE_ARE_BLKOUT will show our collective resolve to support each other in building a better future; one that builds on our strengths, values our differences, and is anything but 'normal'. We want to make clear through actions large and small, how *we* intend to make sure that *our* Black Queer Lives Matter. We hope that you will be ready to join or support us.

Dr Rob Berkeley MBE
October 2020

Selected Bibliography

- A history of community asset ownership « *Locality*. (n.d.). Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <http://locality.org.uk/resources/history-community-asset-ownership/>
- Back, L. (2009). Researching community and its moral projects. *Twenty-first Century Society*, 4(2), 201-214. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <http://research.gold.ac.uk/2322>
- Buller, A. M., Devries, K., Howard, L. M., & Bacchus, L. J. (2014). Associations between Intimate Partner Violence and Health among Men Who Have Sex with Men: A Systematic Review and Meta-Analysis. *PLOS Medicine*, 11(3). Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://journals.plos.org/plosmedicine/article?id=10.1371/journal.pmed.1001609>
- Chalabi, M. (n.d.). *Gay Britain: what do the statistics say?* Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://www.theguardian.com/politics/reality-check/2013/oct/03/gay-britain-what-do-statistics-say>
- Dougan, S., Elford, J., Rice, B., Brown, A. E., Sinka, K., Evans, B., . . . Fenton, K. A. (2005). Epidemiology of HIV among black and minority ethnic men who have sex with men in England and Wales. *Sexually Transmitted Infections*, 81(4), 345-350. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://sti.bmj.com/content/81/4/345>
- Dougan, S., Payne, L. J., Brown, A. E., Fenton, K. A., Logan, L., Evans, B., & Gill, O. N. (2004). Black Caribbean adults with HIV in England, Wales, and Northern Ireland: an emerging epidemic? *Sexually Transmitted Infections*, 80(1), 18-23. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://sti.bmj.com/content/80/1/18>
- Dyer, T. P., Regan, R., Wilton, L., Harawa, N. T., Ou, S. S., Wang, L., & Shoptaw, S. (2013). Differences in Substance Use, Psychosocial Characteristics and HIV-Related Sexual Risk Behavior Between Black Men Who Have Sex with Men Only (BMSMO) and Black Men Who Have Sex with Men and Women (BMSMW) in Six US Cities. *Journal of Urban Health-bulletin of The New York Academy of Medicine*, 90(6), 1181-1193. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11524-013-9811-1>
- Eliacin, J. (2013). Social capital, narratives of fragmentation, and schizophrenia: an ethnographic exploration of factors shaping African-Caribbeans' social capital and mental health in a North London community. *Culture, Medicine and Psychiatry*, 37(3), 465-487. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/pmc4821419>
- Lawrence, M., & Taylor, Y. (2019). The UK Government LGBT Action Plan : discourses of progress, enduring stasis, and LGBTQI+ lives 'getting better'. *Critical Social Policy*, 026101831987728. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://pureportal.strath.ac.uk/en/publications/the-uk-government-lgbt-action-plan-discourses-of-progress-endurin>
- LGBT Action Plan*. (n.d.). Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from Government Equalities Office: https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/721367/GEO-LGBT-Action-Plan.pdf
- Maulsby, C., Millett, G., Lindsey, K., Kelley, R. T., Johnson, K., Montoya, D., & Holtgrave, D. R. (2013). A systematic review of HIV interventions for black men who have sex with men (MSM). *BMC Public Health*, 13(1), 625-625. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/23819660>
- McKeown, E., Doerner, R., Nelson, S., Low, N., Robinson, A., Anderson, J., & Elford, J. (2012). The experiences of ethnic minority MSM using NHS sexual health clinics in Britain. *Sexually Transmitted Infections*, 88(8), 595-600. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://sti.bmj.com/content/88/8/595>
- Millett, G. A., Peterson, J. L., Flores, S. A., Hart, T. A., Hart, T. A., Jeffries, W. L., . . . Remis, R. S. (2012). Comparisons of disparities and risks of HIV infection in black and other men who have sex with men in

- Canada, UK, and USA: a meta-analysis. *The Lancet*, 380(9839), 341-348. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pubmed/22819656>
- Mintchev, N., & Moore, H. L. (2018). Super-diversity and the prosperous society. *European Journal of Social Theory*, 21(1), 117-134. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/1368431016678629>
- Musterd, S., Marcińczak, S., Ham, M. v., & Tammaru, T. (2017). Socio-Economic Segregation in European Capital Cities: Increasing Separation between Poor and Rich. *Urban Geography*, 38(7), 1062-1083. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/02723638.2016.1228371>
- Però, D. (2011). *Policy Change from Below: Recognizing Migrants' Political Agency among Latin Americans in London*. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1057/9781137001887_7
- Ramesh, R. (n.d.). *More black people jailed in England and Wales proportionally than in US*. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://www.theguardian.com/society/2010/oct/11/black-prison-population-increase-england>
- Sturgis, P., Brunton-Smith, I., Kuha, J., & Jackson, J. (2014). Ethnic diversity, segregation, and the social cohesion of neighbourhoods in London. *Ethnic and Racial Studies*, 37(8), 1286-1309. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/01419870.2013.831932>
- Sullivan, P. S., Peterson, J. L., Rosenberg, E. S., Kelley, C. F., Cooper, H. L., Vaughan, A. S., . . . Sanchez, T. (2014). Understanding Racial HIV/STI Disparities in Black and White Men Who Have Sex with Men: A Multilevel Approach. *PLOS ONE*, 9(3), 1. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0090514>
- The Assets of Community Value (England) Regulations 2012*. (2015). Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <http://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukxi/2012/2421/contents/made>
- Wickes, R., Zahnow, R., White, G., & Mazerolle, L. (2014). Ethnic diversity and its impact on community social cohesion and neighborly exchange. *Journal of Urban Affairs*, 36(1), 51-78. Retrieved 10 28, 2020, from <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/abs/10.1111/juaf.12015>
- Mickey E. White, Angie D. Cartwright, Ana G. Reyes, Hailey Morris, Natalya A. Lindo, Anneliese A. Singh & Caitlyn McKinzie Bennett (2020) "A Whole Other Layer of Complexity": Black Transgender Men's Experiences, *Journal of LGBT Issues in Counseling*, 14:3, 248-267, DOI: [10.1080/15538605.2020.1790468](https://doi.org/10.1080/15538605.2020.1790468)

**WE_
ARE
BLK
OUT**



BLKOUTUK.COM



**BLACK QUEER MEN WHO
RAISE OUR VOICES
TAKE THE LEAD
SHARE OUR LIGHT
STAND TOGETHER**

JOIN US | SUPPORT US